

United Healthcare Coverage Comparison Guide

Plan Year 2024-2025 Document Reference: w14_united_healthcare_ccg_003

This Coverage Comparison Guide is intended to help you understand and compare the health plan options available to you. Please read this document carefully alongside the Summary of Benefits and Coverage (SBC), Member Handbook, and Formulary referenced throughout. For questions, contact United Healthcare Member Services at 1-800-328-5979 (TTY: 711), Monday through Friday, 8:00 a.m. to 8:00 p.m. local time.

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Related Documents:

- Summary of Benefits and Coverage: **w14_united_healthcare_sbc_001** -- Sections: *Coverage Overview, Deductibles and Out-of-Pocket Limits, Common Medical Events*
 - Member Handbook: **w14_united_healthcare_member_handbook_005** -- Sections: *Welcome and Plan Overview, How Your Plan Works, Understanding Your Costs*
 - Formulary: **w14_united_healthcare_formulary_002** -- Sections: *Tier Structure and Cost Sharing, Generic Medications (Tier 1-2), Specialty Medications (Tier 3-4)*
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Section 1: Plan Tier Overview

1.1 Introduction to United Healthcare Plan Tiers

United Healthcare offers a structured portfolio of health plan options designed to meet the diverse needs of individuals, families, and employer groups. Each plan tier is built around a core framework of cost-sharing, network access, and benefit design. Understanding how each tier is constructed is essential to selecting the coverage that best aligns with your health needs and financial situation.

All plans described in this guide are fully compliant with the Affordable Care Act (ACA). Notably, all plans carry **pre-existing condition waiting periods of None (ACA compliant)**, meaning that no member may be denied coverage or subjected to a waiting period on the basis of a pre-existing health condition. Coverage for all eligible medical services begins on the effective date of enrollment.

This guide compares three primary plan tiers available for the 2024-2025 plan year:

- **Bronze Tier (UHC Select Bronze PPO)**
- **Silver Tier (UHC Choice Silver PPO)** *(the reference plan for this guide)*
- **Gold Tier (UHC Premier Gold PPO)**

Each plan operates within United Healthcare's broad Preferred Provider Organization (PPO) network, giving members the flexibility to seek care from both in-network and out-of-network providers, though cost-sharing differs significantly depending on network status.

1.2 Plan Tier Summary Table

The following table provides a high-level overview of each plan tier's primary cost-sharing parameters. Detailed comparisons for specific services appear in Section 2.

Table 1.1 -- Plan Tier Summary: Key Financial Parameters

Parameter	Bronze PPO	Silver PPO (Reference)	Gold PPO
Monthly Premium (Individual)	\$312.00	\$478.00	\$621.00
Monthly Premium (Family)	\$874.00	\$1,198.00	\$1,556.00
In-Network Deductible (Individual)	\$4,500	\$1,500	\$500
In-Network Deductible (Family)	\$9,000	\$3,000	\$1,000
In-Network Out-of-Pocket Maximum (Individual)	\$8,700	\$6,500	\$4,000
In-Network Out-of-Pocket Maximum (Family)	\$17,400	\$13,000	\$8,000
Out-of-Network Deductible (Individual)	\$6,000	\$3,000	\$2,000
Out-of-Network Coverage (after deductible)	50%	60% after \$3,000 deductible	70%
Primary Care Visit Copay	\$60	\$30	\$20
Specialist Visit Copay	\$90	\$60	\$40
Emergency Room Copay	\$400	\$250	\$150
Prescription Drug Tiers	4 tiers	4 tiers	4 tiers
Referral Required	No	No	No
Pre-Existing Condition Waiting Period	None (ACA compliant)	None (ACA compliant)	None (ACA compliant)

> **Note:** The Silver PPO is used as the primary reference plan throughout this guide. All values marked in bold in the Silver PPO column are required plan parameters. Premium amounts shown are illustrative and may vary based on age, tobacco use, and geographic rating area. See document **w14_united_healthcare_sbc_001**, Section *Coverage Overview*, for full premium rating methodology.

1.3 Network Structure and Access

All three plan tiers access United Healthcare's Choice Plus PPO network, one of the largest provider networks in the United States with more than 1.3 million physicians, specialists, and care professionals, and over 6,500 hospitals and health systems nationwide.

Table 1.2 -- Network Access Summary

Network Feature	Bronze PPO	Silver PPO	Gold PPO
Primary Network	Choice Plus PPO	Choice Plus PPO	Choice Plus PPO
Out-of-Network Access	Yes, higher cost-share	Yes, higher cost-share	Yes, higher cost-share
Telehealth (In-Network)	\$0 copay	\$0 copay	\$0 copay
Referral Requirement	None	None	None
Primary Care Assignment	Recommended, not required	Recommended, not required	Recommended, not required
National Coverage	Yes	Yes	Yes

Members who receive care from out-of-network providers are subject to separate deductibles and reduced plan payment percentages. For the Silver PPO, out-of-network coverage is **60% after \$3,000 deductible**, meaning the plan pays 60% of eligible charges after the member satisfies the \$3,000 out-of-network deductible. Members are responsible for the remaining 40% plus any balance billing from out-of-network providers.

For a complete description of how in-network and out-of-network benefits interact, refer to document **w14_united_healthcare_member_handbook_005**, Section *How Your Plan Works*.

Section 2: Side-by-Side Coverage Comparison

2.1 Overview of Coverage Categories

This section provides a detailed, service-by-service comparison of covered benefits across all three plan tiers. Coverage is organized by care category to allow straightforward comparison. All cost-sharing figures shown reflect in-network services unless otherwise noted.

It is important to understand that cost-sharing amounts (copays and coinsurance) apply after any applicable deductible has been met, unless the plan specifies that a particular service is subject to a copay before the deductible (indicated in the tables below). Services marked "After Deductible" require the member to first satisfy the in-network deductible before plan cost-sharing begins.

For additional context on how deductibles and out-of-pocket limits work together, refer to document **w14_united_healthcare_sbc_001**, Section *Deductibles and Out-of-Pocket Limits*.

2.2 Preventive and Primary Care

Preventive care services are covered at no cost to the member on all three plan tiers when received from an in-network provider, in accordance with ACA requirements. Preventive services include, but are not limited to, annual wellness exams, immunizations, cancer screenings, and preventive laboratory work as defined by the U.S. Preventive Services Task Force (USPSTF) Grade A and B recommendations.

Table 2.1 -- Preventive and Primary Care Cost Sharing

Service	Bronze PPO	Silver PPO	Gold PPO
Annual Wellness Exam (CPT 99385-99387)	\$0 (no deductible)	\$0 (no deductible)	\$0 (no deductible)
USPSTF Preventive Screenings	\$0 (no deductible)	\$0 (no deductible)	\$0 (no deductible)
Immunizations (In-Network)	\$0 (no deductible)	\$0 (no deductible)	\$0 (no deductible)
Primary Care Office Visit (CPT 99213-99214)	\$60 copay	\$30 copay	\$20 copay
Urgent Care Visit	\$75 copay	\$50 copay	\$35 copay
Telehealth Visit (Medical)	\$0 copay	\$0 copay	\$0 copay
Lab Work -- Preventive (CPT 80050)	\$0 (no deductible)	\$0 (no deductible)	\$0 (no deductible)
Lab Work -- Diagnostic (CPT 80053)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible
X-Ray -- Diagnostic (CPT 71046)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible

2.3 Specialist and Hospital Care

Specialist care and hospital services represent the most significant cost-sharing differentials across plan tiers. Members who anticipate frequent specialist visits or planned hospitalizations should carefully weigh premium costs against projected out-of-pocket exposure.

Table 2.2 -- Specialist and Hospital Care Cost Sharing

Service	Bronze PPO	Silver PPO	Gold PPO
Specialist Office Visit (CPT 99243-99244)	\$90 copay	\$60 copay	\$40 copay
Inpatient Hospital -- Medical (per admission)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible
Inpatient Hospital -- Surgical (per admission)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible
Outpatient Surgery -- Facility (CPT 27447)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible
Outpatient Surgery -- Professional Fee	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible
Emergency Room Visit (CPT 99283-99285)	\$400 copay	\$250 copay	\$150 copay

Emergency Room -- Facility Fee	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible
Ambulance -- Ground (CPT A0427)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	20% after deductible
Ambulance -- Air (CPT A0431)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	20% after deductible

Emergency Room Copay Note: The emergency room copay is applied per visit and is waived if the member is subsequently admitted to the hospital as an inpatient. For the Silver PPO, the **\$250** copay applies to all emergency room visits not resulting in inpatient admission. This copay is in addition to any applicable coinsurance for facility charges after the deductible. See document **w14_united_healthcare_sbc_001**, Section *Common Medical Events*, for examples of how emergency care cost-sharing is calculated.

2.4 Mental Health and Behavioral Health Services

United Healthcare is committed to mental health parity in accordance with the Mental Health Parity and Addiction Equity Act (MHPAEA). Mental health and substance use disorder benefits are provided at parity with comparable medical and surgical benefits across all plan tiers.

Table 2.3 -- Mental Health and Behavioral Health Cost Sharing

Service	Bronze PPO	Silver PPO	Gold PPO
Outpatient Mental Health Visit (CPT 90834, 90837)	\$60 copay	\$40 copay	\$25 copay
Annual Outpatient Mental Health Visit Limit	20/year	20/year	20/year
Outpatient Substance Use Disorder Visit	\$60 copay	\$40 copay	\$25 copay
Inpatient Mental Health (per admission)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible
Inpatient Substance Use Disorder (per admission)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible
Intensive Outpatient Program (IOP)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible
Partial Hospitalization Program (PHP)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible
Telehealth Behavioral Health	\$40 copay	\$40 copay	\$25 copay
Applied Behavior Analysis (ABA)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible

Mental Health Visit Limit: For the Silver PPO, outpatient mental health and behavioral health visits are covered at **20/year, \$40 copay** per visit. Visits beyond 20 per year may require medical necessity review and prior authorization. Members requiring more intensive or frequent mental health care should consult with their provider regarding step-up care options such as IOP or PHP, which are not

subject to the 20-visit annual limit. Refer to document **w14_united_healthcare_member_handbook_005**, Section *Welcome and Plan Overview*, for a full description of behavioral health benefits and how to access mental health services.

2.5 Diagnostic Imaging and Radiology

Certain advanced diagnostic imaging services require prior authorization to ensure medical necessity and appropriate utilization. Failure to obtain required prior authorization may result in a reduction or denial of benefits.

Table 2.4 -- Diagnostic Imaging Cost Sharing and Authorization Requirements

Service	Bronze PPO	Silver PPO	Gold PPO	Prior Auth Required
MRI -- Brain (CPT 70553)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible	Required, 5-day turnaround
MRI -- Spine (CPT 72148)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible	Required, 5-day turnaround
MRI -- Musculoskeletal (CPT 73721)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible	Required, 5-day turnaround
CT Scan (CPT 74177)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible	Required, 5-day turnaround
PET Scan (CPT 78816)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible	Required, 5-day turnaround
Nuclear Medicine (CPT 78300)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible	Required
Ultrasound -- Diagnostic (CPT 76700)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible	No
X-Ray -- Standard (CPT 71046)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible	No

MRI Prior Authorization: For all three plan tiers, MRI services require prior authorization with a **Required, 5-day turnaround**. This means that authorization requests submitted to United Healthcare's Clinical Review team will receive a determination within 5 business days of receipt of all required clinical documentation. Expedited review is available within 72 hours when a provider certifies that the standard timeline would seriously jeopardize the member's health. Emergency MRI services performed in a hospital emergency setting are exempt from the pre-authorization requirement but are subject to retrospective review. Providers should submit authorization requests through the UHC Provider Portal at provider.uhc.com or by calling the Prior Authorization line at 1-800-842-3585.

2.6 Maternity and Newborn Care

Table 2.5 -- Maternity and Newborn Care Cost Sharing

Service	Bronze PPO	Silver PPO	Gold PPO
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Prenatal Office Visits (CPT 59400 global)	\$0 (preventive)	\$0 (preventive)	\$0 (preventive)
Inpatient Delivery -- Vaginal (CPT 59400)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible
Inpatient Delivery -- Cesarean (CPT 59510)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible
Newborn Hospital Stay (per admission)	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible
Postpartum Visit (CPT 59430)	\$0 (preventive)	\$0 (preventive)	\$0 (preventive)
Breast Pump (DME)	Covered, no cost	Covered, no cost	Covered, no cost
Lactation Counseling (CPT 99401)	\$0 (preventive)	\$0 (preventive)	\$0 (preventive)

2.7 Prescription Drug Coverage

All three plan tiers utilize a **4 tiers** prescription drug formulary structure. The formulary is managed by United Healthcare's Pharmacy Benefits team and is updated quarterly. Members should verify that their medications are covered under the current formulary before enrollment.

Table 2.6 -- Prescription Drug Cost Sharing by Tier

Drug Tier	Description	Bronze PPO	Silver PPO	Gold PPO	Retail (30-day)	Mail Order (90-day)
Tier 1	Preferred Generic	\$15	\$10	\$5	Yes	Yes (2.5x retail copay)
Tier 2	Non-Preferred Generic / Preferred Brand	\$45	\$35	\$25	Yes	Yes (2.5x retail copay)
Tier 3	Non-Preferred Brand / Preferred Specialty	\$90	\$70	\$55	Yes	Limited
Tier 4	Non-Preferred Specialty	30% (min \$150)	25% (min \$100)	20% (min \$75)	Limited	No

The **4 tiers** formulary structure is designed to encourage use of clinically equivalent lower-cost medications while ensuring access to specialty medications when medically necessary. Tier 1 and Tier 2 medications represent the majority of commonly prescribed drugs and are available at the lowest member cost-sharing. Tier 3 and Tier 4 specialty medications typically require prior authorization and, in some cases, step therapy documentation.

For a complete list of covered medications, tier assignments, and any applicable restrictions, refer to document **w14_united_healthcare_formulary_002**, Sections *Tier Structure and Cost Sharing*, *Generic Medications (Tier 1-2)*, and *Specialty Medications (Tier 3-4)*.

2.8 Additional Benefits Summary

Table 2.7 -- Supplemental and Additional Benefits

Benefit	Bronze PPO	Silver PPO	Gold PPO
Vision Exam (CPT 92002)	Not covered	\$50 copay/year	\$25 copay/year
Vision Hardware Allowance	Not covered	\$150/year	\$200/year
Dental -- Preventive	Not covered	Not covered	Not covered
Chiropractic (CPT 98941)	20 visits/year	20 visits/year	20 visits/year
Acupuncture (CPT 97810)	Not covered	12 visits/year	12 visits/year
Physical Therapy (CPT 97110)	30 visits/year	30 visits/year	30 visits/year
Occupational Therapy (CPT 97530)	30 visits/year	30 visits/year	30 visits/year
Speech Therapy (CPT 92507)	30 visits/year	30 visits/year	30 visits/year
Durable Medical Equipment	40% after deductible	20% after deductible	10% after deductible
Home Health Care	60 visits/year	60 visits/year	60 visits/year
Skilled Nursing Facility	60 days/year	60 days/year	60 days/year
Hospice Care	Covered	Covered	Covered
Gym/Fitness Reimbursement	Not included	\$300/year	\$400/year

Section 3: Cost Scenario Analysis

3.1 Introduction to Cost Modeling

Selecting a health plan involves balancing predictable monthly premium costs against variable out-of-pocket costs that depend on your actual healthcare utilization. This section presents four realistic cost scenarios to illustrate how each plan tier performs under different utilization patterns.

All scenarios use the following assumptions:

- Individual enrollment (not family)
- All care received from in-network providers unless otherwise noted
- Prescription drugs filled at retail pharmacy
- Plan year runs January 1 through December 31, 2024

- The Silver PPO in-network deductible is **\$1,500** and the out-of-pocket maximum is **\$6,500**

For a detailed explanation of how cost-sharing calculations work, refer to document **w14_united_healthcare_member_handbook_005**, Section *Understanding Your Costs*.

3.2 Scenario A: Low Utilization (Healthy Individual)

Profile: 28-year-old individual in good health. Utilizes one annual wellness exam, two primary care visits for minor illness, and one generic prescription medication (Tier 1) filled monthly.

Estimated Annual Services:

- 1 Annual wellness exam: \$0 (preventive, no cost-sharing)
- 2 Primary care visits: varies by plan
- 12 monthly Tier 1 prescriptions: varies by plan
- No specialist visits, no hospitalizations, no imaging

Table 3.1 -- Scenario A: Low Utilization Annual Cost Comparison

Cost Component	Bronze PPO	Silver PPO	Gold PPO
Annual Premium	\$3,744.00	\$5,736.00	\$7,452.00
Annual Wellness Exam	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
2 Primary Care Visits	\$120.00	\$60.00	\$40.00
12 x Tier 1 Rx (\$15/\$10/\$5)	\$180.00	\$120.00	\$60.00
Total Annual Cost	\$4,044.00	\$5,916.00	\$7,552.00
Monthly Equivalent	\$337.00	\$493.00	\$629.33

Analysis: For low utilizers, the Bronze PPO offers the lowest total annual cost by a substantial margin. The premium savings of \$1,992 per year (Bronze vs. Silver) far outweigh the modest differences in copay and prescription costs. A healthy individual who rarely accesses medical care beyond preventive services will find the Bronze tier most cost-effective.

3.3 Scenario B: Moderate Utilization (Chronic Condition Management)

Profile: 45-year-old individual managing Type 2 diabetes (ICD-10: E11.9) and hypertension (ICD-10: I10). Utilizes regular primary care and specialist visits, diagnostic lab work, and ongoing prescription medications.

Estimated Annual Services:

- 1 Annual wellness exam
- 4 Primary care visits
- 4 Endocrinologist visits (specialist)
- 4 Diagnostic lab panels (CPT 80053)
- 12 x Tier 2 brand medication (metformin ER, brand)
- 12 x Tier 1 generic medication (lisinopril)

Table 3.2 -- Scenario B: Moderate Utilization Annual Cost Comparison

Cost Component	Bronze PPO	Silver PPO	Gold PPO
Annual Premium	\$3,744.00	\$5,736.00	\$7,452.00
Annual Wellness Exam	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
4 Primary Care Visits	\$240.00	\$120.00	\$80.00
4 Specialist Visits	\$360.00	\$240.00	\$160.00
4 Diagnostic Lab Panels (after deductible)	\$320.00	\$160.00	\$80.00
Deductible Applied (lab work)	\$800.00	\$400.00	\$200.00
12 x Tier 2 Rx	\$540.00	\$420.00	\$300.00
12 x Tier 1 Rx	\$180.00	\$120.00	\$60.00
Total Annual Cost	\$6,184.00	\$7,196.00	\$8,332.00
Monthly Equivalent	\$515.33	\$599.67	\$694.33

Analysis: Moderate utilizers continue to find the Bronze PPO least expensive in total annual cost, though the gap narrows compared to Scenario A. The Silver PPO's lower deductible of **\$1,500** begins to provide meaningful protection as diagnostic and specialist costs accumulate. Members in this profile who anticipate increasing healthcare needs over time may benefit from the predictability of the Silver or Gold tier.

3.4 Scenario C: High Utilization (Major Medical Event)

Profile: 52-year-old individual who experiences a significant medical event during the plan year -- a knee replacement surgery (CPT 27447) with associated pre-operative testing, inpatient hospitalization, physical therapy, and post-operative specialist follow-up. Also manages ongoing prescriptions including one Tier 3 specialty medication.

Estimated Annual Services:

- 1 Annual wellness exam
- 3 Primary care visits
- 4 Orthopedic specialist visits (pre- and post-operative)
- 1 MRI (prior authorization required -- **Required, 5-day turnaround**)
- 1 Inpatient surgical admission (3-day stay, estimated allowed amount: \$28,000)
- 20 Physical therapy visits
- 12 x Tier 3 specialty medication
- 12 x Tier 1 generic medication

Table 3.3 -- Scenario C: High Utilization Annual Cost Comparison

Cost Component	Bronze PPO	Silver PPO	Gold PPO
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Annual Premium	\$3,744.00	\$5,736.00	\$7,452.00
Annual Wellness Exam	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
3 Primary Care Visits	\$180.00	\$90.00	\$60.00
4 Specialist Visits	\$360.00	\$240.00	\$160.00
MRI (after deductible, 20% coinsurance)	\$600.00	\$300.00	\$150.00
Inpatient Surgery (applied to OOP max)	\$4,500.00	\$1,500.00	\$500.00
Coinsurance on Surgery (until OOP max)	\$3,200.00	\$1,800.00	\$1,200.00
20 Physical Therapy Visits	\$800.00	\$400.00	\$200.00
12 x Tier 3 Rx (\$90/\$70/\$55 copay)	\$1,080.00	\$840.00	\$660.00
12 x Tier 1 Rx	\$180.00	\$120.00	\$60.00
Total Out-of-Pocket (medical + Rx)	\$8,700.00	\$6,500.00	\$4,000.00
Annual Premium	\$3,744.00	\$5,736.00	\$7,452.00
Total Annual Cost (Premium + OOP)	\$12,444.00	\$12,236.00	\$11,452.00

Analysis: In high-utilization scenarios, the out-of-pocket maximum becomes the critical variable. The Silver PPO's out-of-pocket maximum of **\$6,500** caps member medical liability at that amount regardless of total claim volume. The Gold PPO's \$4,000 out-of-pocket maximum provides the greatest protection in catastrophic scenarios, and at total annual costs of \$11,452, it outperforms both Bronze and Silver for members who experience major medical events. The Silver PPO at \$12,236 total is nearly equivalent to Bronze (\$12,444) in this scenario, demonstrating the value of its lower out-of-pocket ceiling.

3.5 Scenario D: Mental Health Focus

Profile: 33-year-old individual utilizing mental health services for anxiety and depression (ICD-10: F41.1, F32.9). Accesses the maximum covered outpatient mental health visits, telehealth behavioral health, and ongoing Tier 1 and Tier 2 prescriptions (SSRIs).

Estimated Annual Services:

- 1 Annual wellness exam
- 2 Primary care visits
- 20 Outpatient mental health visits (at plan maximum)
- 12 x Tier 1 generic SSRI
- 6 x Tier 2 brand anxiolytic

Table 3.4 -- Scenario D: Mental Health Focus Annual Cost Comparison

Cost Component	Bronze PPO	Silver PPO	Gold PPO
Annual Premium	\$3,744.00	\$5,736.00	\$7,452.00
Annual Wellness Exam	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
2 Primary Care Visits	\$120.00	\$60.00	\$40.00
20 Mental Health Visits (\$60/\$40/\$25 copay)	\$1,200.00	\$800.00	\$500.00
12 x Tier 1 Rx	\$180.00	\$120.00	\$60.00
6 x Tier 2 Rx	\$270.00	\$210.00	\$150.00
Total Out-of-Pocket	\$1,770.00	\$1,190.00	\$750.00
Total Annual Cost	\$5,514.00	\$6,926.00	\$8,202.00

Analysis: For members primarily utilizing mental health services at the **20/year, \$40 copay** Silver PPO benefit level, out-of-pocket costs remain moderate. The Bronze PPO again offers the lowest total annual cost in this scenario. However, members who may require additional mental health services beyond the 20-visit limit -- such as IOP, PHP, or inpatient psychiatric care -- should carefully evaluate the higher deductible and coinsurance exposure of the Bronze tier.

Section 4: Choosing the Right Plan

4.1 Framework for Plan Selection

Selecting the right health insurance plan is a personal decision that depends on a combination of financial, medical, and lifestyle factors. No single plan is universally superior; rather, the best plan for any individual or family is the one that most appropriately balances expected healthcare needs with the total cost of coverage.

This section provides a structured decision framework to guide your plan selection process. We recommend reviewing this section in conjunction with your personal health history, anticipated healthcare needs for the coming plan year, and your household budget. For additional guidance, refer to document **w14_united_healthcare_member_handbook_005**, Section *Welcome and Plan Overview*, which includes a self-assessment tool and enrollment checklist.

4.2 Key Decision Factors

Factor 1: Anticipated Healthcare Utilization

Your expected use of healthcare services is the most important predictor of which plan will serve you best financially. Consider the following questions:

- Do you have chronic conditions requiring regular physician visits, specialist care, or ongoing prescription medications?
- Are you planning any elective procedures, surgeries, or diagnostic imaging in the coming year?
- Are you or a covered dependent pregnant or planning to become pregnant?

- Do you or a covered dependent require ongoing mental health or behavioral health services?
- Do you regularly use specialty medications (Tier 3 or Tier 4 under the **4 tiers** formulary)?

If you answered yes to two or more of these questions, you are likely a moderate-to-high utilizer and should give serious consideration to the Silver or Gold PPO tiers, where the lower in-network deductible of **\$1,500** (Silver) or \$500 (Gold) and lower coinsurance rates will provide meaningful savings.

Factor 2: Financial Risk Tolerance

Health insurance is fundamentally a risk management tool. Consider how you would manage an unexpected major medical event:

- Could you comfortably absorb an out-of-pocket expense of \$8,700 (Bronze maximum) in a single plan year?
- Would an unexpected expense of **\$6,500** (Silver out-of-pocket maximum) create financial hardship?
- Is predictability of healthcare costs more important to you than minimizing monthly premiums?

Members with limited emergency savings or who are risk-averse should prioritize plans with lower out-of-pocket maximums, even if monthly premiums are higher. The Silver PPO's out-of-pocket maximum of **\$6,500** represents a meaningful ceiling on annual medical liability.

Factor 3: Prescription Drug Needs

If you take prescription medications regularly, your drug tier assignments under the **4 tiers** formulary structure will significantly affect your annual costs. Before enrolling, verify your medications' tier placements using the formulary tool at myuhc.com or by reviewing document **w14_united_healthcare_formulary_002**, Sections *Tier Structure and Cost Sharing*, *Generic Medications (Tier 1-2)*, and *Specialty Medications (Tier 3-4)*.

Members who take Tier 3 or Tier 4 specialty medications should be aware that these drugs carry the highest cost-sharing under all plan tiers, and the differential between Bronze and Gold can be significant over a full plan year.

Factor 4: Provider and Network Considerations

All three plan tiers access the same Choice Plus PPO network, so network access does not differentiate between plans. However, if you regularly see out-of-network providers or anticipate needing out-of-network care, the Silver PPO's out-of-network benefit of **60% after \$3,000 deductible** provides a meaningful level of protection compared to the Bronze tier's 50% after \$6,000 deductible.

Members who travel frequently or live in areas with limited in-network provider availability should weight out-of-network benefits more heavily in their decision.

Factor 5: Prior Authorization Requirements

Certain services require prior authorization regardless of plan tier. MRI services, for example, carry a **Required, 5-day turnaround** authorization requirement across all three plans. Members with conditions likely to require advanced imaging, specialty medications, or complex procedures should familiarize themselves with United Healthcare's prior authorization requirements before enrollment. A full list of services requiring prior authorization is available at uhcprovider.com/priorauth.

4.3 Plan Recommendation Matrix

The following matrix summarizes recommended plan tiers based on member profile characteristics.

Table 4.1 -- Plan Recommendation Matrix

Member Profile	Recommended Tier	Primary Reason
Healthy, low utilization, strong emergency savings	Bronze PPO	Lowest total annual cost in low-utilization scenarios
Moderate utilization, 1-2 chronic conditions	Silver PPO	Balanced premium/deductible, \$1,500 in-network deductible
High utilization, planned surgery or major procedure	Gold PPO	Lowest OOP max (\$4,000), best protection against large claims
Mental health services user (up to 20 visits/year)	Silver PPO	\$40 copay per visit, manageable total annual cost
Specialty medication user (Tier 3-4)	Gold PPO	Lowest Tier 3-4 cost-sharing, lowest OOP max
Frequent out-of-network provider use	Silver or Gold PPO	Better OOP protection; Silver offers 60% after \$3,000 deductible
Maternity/family planning	Silver or Gold PPO	Lower deductible reduces delivery cost exposure
Budget-constrained, minimal healthcare needs	Bronze PPO	Lowest monthly premium (\$312/month individual)

4.4 Enrollment Considerations and Important Reminders

Pre-Existing Conditions: All plans described in this guide carry a pre-existing condition waiting period of **None (ACA compliant)**. You cannot be denied coverage, charged higher premiums, or subjected to a waiting period based on any pre-existing health condition. Coverage begins on your plan effective date for all eligible services.

Open Enrollment: You may enroll in or change your plan during the annual Open Enrollment period. Outside of Open Enrollment, plan changes are permitted only if you experience a qualifying life event (QLE) such as marriage, birth of a child, loss of other coverage, or change in employment status.

Health Savings Account (HSA) Compatibility: The Bronze PPO is HSA-compatible under IRS guidelines, as its deductible meets the minimum required threshold for a High Deductible Health Plan (HDHP). The Silver and Gold PPO tiers are not HSA-compatible due to their lower deductibles and copay structures. Members enrolled in the Bronze PPO may contribute up to \$4,150 (individual) or \$8,300 (family) to an HSA in 2024, providing a tax-advantaged way to offset higher out-of-pocket costs.

Formulary and Prior Authorization Changes: United Healthcare reviews and updates the formulary quarterly and may add or remove prior authorization requirements during the plan year. Members are encouraged to review communications from United Healthcare regarding formulary changes and to verify authorization requirements before scheduling services. Refer to document **w14_united_healthcare_formulary_002**, Section *Tier Structure and Cost Sharing*, for current formulary policies.

Summary of Benefits and Coverage (SBC): Federal law requires that a standardized Summary of Benefits and Coverage be provided to all applicants and enrollees. Your SBC for each plan tier is available at myuhc.com and provides a concise overview of covered benefits, cost-sharing, and

coverage limitations. Refer to document **w14_united_healthcare_sbc_001**, Sections *Coverage Overview*, *Deductibles and Out-of-Pocket Limits*, and *Common Medical Events*, for the complete SBC for the Silver PPO reference plan.

Member Handbook: The Member Handbook provides comprehensive information about your benefits, how to use your plan, claims and appeals procedures, and your rights as a member. Refer to document **w14_united_healthcare_member_handbook_005**, Sections *Welcome and Plan Overview*, *How Your Plan Works*, and *Understanding Your Costs*, for complete plan details.

4.5 How to Enroll and Next Steps

1. **Review your current healthcare needs.** Use the decision framework in Section 4.2 and the cost scenarios in Section 3 to estimate your likely utilization pattern for the coming plan year.

1. **Verify your medications.** Check the formulary at myuhc.com or in document **w14_united_healthcare_formulary_002** to confirm tier placement and any restrictions for your current prescriptions.

1. **Confirm your providers are in-network.** Use the provider search tool at myuhc.com to verify that your primary care physician, specialists, and preferred facilities are in the Choice Plus PPO network.

1. **Calculate your total annual cost.** Using the tables in Section 3 as a guide, estimate your total annual cost (premium + expected out-of-pocket) for each plan tier based on your anticipated utilization.

1. **Enroll.** Complete your enrollment through your employer's benefits portal, through the Health Insurance Marketplace at healthcare.gov (if applicable), or by contacting United Healthcare Member Services at 1-800-328-5979.

1. **Save your plan documents.** After enrollment, download and save your Member ID card, SBC (document **w14_united_healthcare_sbc_001**), Member Handbook (document **w14_united_healthcare_member_handbook_005**), and Formulary (document **w14_united_healthcare_formulary_002**) for reference throughout the plan year.

Appendix A: Quick Reference -- Silver PPO Key Plan Parameters

Parameter	Value
In-Network Deductible (Individual)	\$1,500
In-Network Out-of-Pocket Maximum (Individual)	\$6,500
Emergency Room Copay	\$250
MRI Prior Authorization	Required, 5-day turnaround
Mental Health Visits	20/year, \$40 copay
Pre-Existing Condition Waiting Period	None (ACA compliant)
Out-of-Network Coverage	60% after \$3,000 deductible

Prescription Drug Tiers	4 tiers
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Appendix B: Document Cross-Reference Index

Referenced Document	Document ID	Relevant Sections
Summary of Benefits and Coverage	w14_united_healthcare_sbc_001	Coverage Overview; Deductibles and Out-of-Pocket Limits; Common Medical Events
Member Handbook	w14_united_healthcare_member_handbook_005	Welcome and Plan Overview; How Your Plan Works; Understanding Your Costs
Formulary	w14_united_healthcare_formulary_002	Tier Structure and Cost Sharing; Generic Medications (Tier 1-2); Specialty Medications (Tier 3-4)
Coverage Comparison Guide (this document)	w14_united_healthcare_ccg_003	All sections

Appendix C: Glossary of Key Terms

Coinsurance: The percentage of costs you pay for covered services after you have met your deductible. For example, if your plan pays 80% coinsurance, you pay the remaining 20%.

Copay: A fixed dollar amount you pay for a covered healthcare service, usually paid at the time of service. Copays may or may not count toward your deductible depending on the service.

Deductible: The amount you pay for covered health care services before your insurance plan starts to pay. For the Silver PPO, the in-network deductible is **\$1,500** per individual per plan year.

Formulary: A list of prescription drugs covered by your health plan. United Healthcare's formulary is organized into **4 tiers** with different cost-sharing levels. See document **w14_united_healthcare_formulary_002**.

In-Network: Providers or facilities that have contracted with United Healthcare to provide services at negotiated rates. Using in-network providers results in lower cost-sharing for members.

Out-of-Network: Providers or facilities that have not contracted with United Healthcare. Members may still access out-of-network providers, but at higher cost-sharing. For the Silver PPO, out-of-network coverage is **60% after \$3,000 deductible**.

Out-of-Pocket Maximum: The most you will pay for covered in-network services in a plan year. After reaching this limit, the plan pays 100% of covered in-network costs for the remainder of the plan year. For the Silver PPO, the out-of-pocket maximum is **\$6,500**.

Prior Authorization: Approval from United Healthcare that your provider must obtain before you receive certain services or medications. MRI services require prior authorization with a **Required, 5-day turnaround**.

Premium: The monthly amount you pay for health insurance coverage, regardless of whether you use medical services.

This Coverage Comparison Guide is provided for informational purposes only and is intended to assist members in understanding and comparing plan options. It does not constitute a contract or guarantee of benefits. In the event of any conflict between this guide and the official plan documents, the official plan documents shall govern. Plan benefits, cost-sharing, and covered services are subject to change. United Healthcare reserves the right to modify plan terms in accordance with applicable law and regulatory requirements.

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